

Outcome Bias

Wacky Wednesdays · Professional Minds · Week 5

Was the decision sound given what was known then, or did we only like the result?

Separate decision quality from result quality, luck, and hindsight.

Today's finish line

DO THIS See the core move.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Reconstruct information available at decision time and inspect process, not just outcome.

DO THIS Try it on a bounded example.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Two hires use the same structured process; one leaves for an unrelated reason. Evaluate the decision without importing hindsight.

DO THIS State evidence and limits.

WHAT THIS MEANS

Decision context, process evidence, sample size, and a separate result description.

What does this prove, and what does it not prove?

DO THIS → WHAT THIS MEANS → FIND THIS YOURSELF → DEMAND DOCUMENTATION
VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE → KEEP THE RECEIPT

The mental model

The idea

Outcome bias, also called historian error, evaluates a choice by its result. A good process can meet bad luck; a careless choice can get lucky.

The boundary

Fair process review does not excuse negligence, and separating outcome from process does not mean ignoring real consequences.

FIND THIS YOURSELF Before accepting a conclusion, name the observation that would support it.

A worked computing example

DO THIS Apply the idea to this bounded case: Two hires use the same structured process; one leaves for an unrelated reason. Evaluate the decision without importing hindsight.

First pass

- ▶ What is known now?
- ▶ Which step or assumption is visible?
- ▶ Where is the checkpoint?

Professional move

For an incident, record what was known, what checks were run, and what process was reasonable before judging the result.

Label the application: This is an instructor/computing translation, not a claim about the primary source.

Ask before the answer

Was the decision sound given what was known then, or did we only like the result?

Predict

What would you expect if the first story were incomplete?

Compare

What alternative explanation deserves a fair test?

PAIR TALK: Make one claim, one reason, and one uncertainty visible.

Do this: make the move visible

DO THIS Split the sentence “it worked, so it was right” into result, decision, information, process, and uncertainty.

1. Write the task, decision, or claim in one sentence.
2. Mark the relevant stages, evidence, comparison, or criteria.
3. Choose one checkpoint before you act or explain.
4. Say what would make you revise, stop, or continue.

VERIFY ON YOUR MACHINE A good first attempt leaves a receipt another person can inspect.

What the source supports — and its limits

Supports

- ▶ Process review, time-of-decision information, and larger samples reduce outcome bias.
- ▶ A clearer question and a more bounded next move.

Does not prove

A single postmortem cannot prove skill, causation, or a repeatable principle from a lucky result.

Is this safe? Is this secure?

How do I know? Where can I verify that?

Recovery: when the first story fails

PAUSE

A failed check is information about the route.

Use one bounded recovery

1. Preserve the observation and context.
2. Name the assumption or step to inspect.
3. Make one smaller retry or ask for help.
4. Do not turn uncertainty into a confident story.

Watch for: Hindsight, tiny samples, and praise/blame assigned only from the final result.

Keep the receipt

DO THIS Record the smallest useful evidence.

- ▶ Claim or decision
- ▶ Observation and context
- ▶ Reasoning / comparison / checkpoint
- ▶ Result, limit, and next action

Exit move

Rewrite one outcome-based judgment as two questions: how did it turn out, and was the decision understandable then?

KEEP THE RECEIPT A concise receipt beats a confident story.

Your next move

Rewrite one outcome-based judgment as two questions: how did it turn out, and was the decision understandable then?

How will you know?